

SGSITS MUN 2026



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MAHABHARAT COMMITTEE

STUDY GUIDE

AGENDA

Palace Intrigue, Strategic Diplomacy, Espionage,
Succession and the Dynamics of Court Politics

राजदरबार की राजनीति, कूटनीति, गुप्तचर व्यवस्था एवं
आंतरिक शक्ति-संतुलन

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Letter from Bureau

MAHABHARAT - “जहाँ सत्ता केवल सिंहासन नहीं, एक उत्तरदायित्व होती है; जहाँ निर्णय केवल वर्तमान नहीं, इतिहास की दिशा तय करते हैं।”

“प्रजा सुखे सुखं राज्ञः प्रजानां च हिते हितम्।”

“In the happiness of his people lies the happiness of the king; in their welfare lies his welfare.”

The Mahabharata is not merely an epic of dynasties and battles; it is a profound exploration of राजधर्म, नीति, कूटनीति, नेतृत्व और सत्ता के स्वरूप. Its timeless narrative unfolds through royal assemblies, intricate alliances, succession, diplomacy and strategic counsel, revealing a world where the destiny of kingdoms was shaped not merely by power, but by the wisdom behind it.

The agenda “Palace Intrigue, Strategic Diplomacy, Espionage, Succession and the Dynamics of Court Politics” invites delegates to explore this intricate political landscape through the lens of the Mahabharata.

राजदरबार की राजनीति, कूटनीति, गुप्तचर व्यवस्था एवं आंतरिक शक्ति-संतुलन के माध्यम से समिति उत्तराधिकार, राजकीय गठबंधनों, गुप्तचर व्यवस्था, रणनीतिक संवाद और सत्ता के संतुलन जैसे महत्वपूर्ण आयामों पर विचार करेगी। यह वह संसार था जहाँ शब्द भी रणनीति थे, संबंध भी राजनीति का हिस्सा थे और प्रत्येक निर्णय राज्य के भविष्य को प्रभावित कर सकता था।

Diplomacy in the Mahabharata was an art of dialogue, timing and foresight. The role of envoys, counsel, alliances and negotiation demonstrates that the fate of kingdoms was often shaped as much within the Sabha as on the battlefield. Similarly, intelligence and strategic information formed an unseen yet significant dimension of governance.

At its heart, however, lies the enduring question of dharma; the balance between personal duty, political responsibility and the greater good. The Mahabharata presents no simple answers; instead, it invites us to examine the consequences of choices made at moments of uncertainty.

Through this committee delegates will be exploring the timeless dimensions of leadership, governance and diplomacy. It is a space where history becomes dialogue, diplomacy becomes strategy, and ancient wisdom meets the discourse of the modern world.

“इतिहास केवल बीती हुई कथा नहीं; वह उन निर्णयों का दर्पण है, जिनसे भविष्य आकार लेता है।”

Looking forward to a committee where at the end each one carries back great experience and good memories.

Regards,

Chairperson - Paridhi Arora
Vice Chair - Shrajal Pal
Rapporteur - Sonam Gurjar

Introduction to the Committee

The Mahabharat Committee is a tribute to India's timeless intellectual, cultural and philosophical heritage, drawing inspiration from one of the greatest epics of Indian civilisation the Mahabharata. Far beyond the narrative of a great war, the Mahabharata is an enduring exploration of Dharma, leadership, governance, diplomacy, justice and the complexities of human nature.

The committee seeks to bridge the wisdom of ancient India with the realities of the modern world. Through the study of historical events, royal assemblies, strategic alliances, diplomatic negotiations and ethical dilemmas, delegates will explore the principles of statecraft, decision-making, conflict resolution and responsible leadership.

Rooted in the richness of Bhartiya Gyan Parampara, the committee provides a platform for intellectual discourse, critical thinking and meaningful deliberation. It encourages participants to examine the relevance of ancient philosophies in contemporary governance, parliamentary institutions and international relations, fostering a deeper understanding of India's civilisational legacy.

Historical Background

The Kingdom of Hastinapur | हस्तिनापुर का साम्राज्य: The Mahabharata unfolds in the ancient kingdom of Hastinapur, the seat of the Kuru dynasty. Under the reign of King Shantanu, followed by the legacy of Bhishma, Dhritarashtra and Pandu, the kingdom became the centre of a complex political and dynastic history. हस्तिनापुर केवल एक राज्य नहीं, अपितु सत्ता, उत्तराधिकार एवं राजधर्म का प्रमुख केंद्र था।

The Kuru Dynasty | कुरुवंश: The rivalry between the Kauravas, led by Duryodhana, and the Pandavas, led by Yudhishtira, shaped the political destiny of Hastinapur. The question of succession brought forth dilemmas of न्याय, धर्म, अधिकार एवं कर्तव्य, laying the foundation for one of the epic's most significant conflicts.

The Royal Court of Hastinapur | हस्तिनापुर की राजसभा: The royal court, guided by eminent figures such as Bhishma, Vidura, Dronacharya and Kripacharya, was a centre of governance, counsel and political deliberation. The Sabha reflected the importance of राजनीति, नीतिशास्त्र, परामर्श एवं निर्णय-निर्माण in the functioning of a kingdom.

Diplomacy and the Quest for Peace | कूटनीति एवं शांति प्रयास: As tensions between the Pandavas and Kauravas escalated, Shri Krishna undertook a diplomatic mission to Hastinapur, seeking a peaceful settlement. His efforts highlight the significance of संधि, संवाद, दूतनीति एवं रणनीतिक कूटनीति in resolving political disputes.

The Kurukshetra War | कुरुक्षेत्र का महायुद्ध: The failure of diplomatic negotiations culminated in the great war of Kurukshetra, where the Pandavas and Kauravas confronted each other in a decisive struggle. The battlefield became a setting for profound questions of धर्म-अधर्म, नेतृत्व, न्याय एवं मानवीय उत्तरदायित्व.

The Bhagavad Gita | श्रीमद्भगवद्गीता: On the battlefield of Kurukshetra, Shri Krishna imparted the wisdom of the Bhagavad Gita to Arjuna, addressing his moral dilemma and illuminating the principles of कर्मयोग, स्वधर्म एवं निष्काम कर्म. These teachings continue to shape philosophical thought and discussions on ethical leadership.

The Legacy of the Mahabharata | महाभारत की विरासत: Beyond the events of the war, the Mahabharata preserves enduring ideas of governance, diplomacy, justice and human values. Its concepts of राजधर्म, सभा-परंपरा एवं लोककल्याण offer a rich foundation for exploring the relationship between ancient Indian political thought and contemporary institutions.

Kuru Dynasty & Family Tree

The **Kuru Dynasty** forms the central political lineage of the Mahabharata, with **Hastinapura** serving as its principal seat of power. The dynasty traces its lineage through **King Shantanu**, whose descendants form the two branches that eventually become central to the succession dispute: the **Pandavas** and the **Kauravas**.

Shantanu's marriage to **Ganga** resulted in the birth of **Devavrata**, later known as **Bhishma**. His subsequent marriage to **Satyavati** produced **Chitrangada** and **Vichitravirya**. Following Vichitravirya's death without an heir, the continuation of the Kuru lineage was ensured through **Vyasa**, whose sons **Dhritarashtra** and **Pandu** became the fathers of the two principal rival branches of the dynasty. **Vidura**, also born to Vyasa, served as an important counsellor within the Kuru court.

Dhritarashtra and **Gandhari** had one hundred sons, the eldest being **Duryodhana**, along with a daughter, **Duhshala**. Pandu's five sons—**Yudhishtira**, **Bhima**, **Arjuna**, **Nakula** and **Sahadeva**—came to be known as the Pandavas. Although raised within the same royal household, the two branches developed increasingly competing political interests.

The question of succession became a defining issue within the Kuru court. The position of **Yudhishtira as the eldest of the Pandava brothers**, the authority of Dhritarashtra, and Duryodhana's ambitions created competing claims and loyalties within the kingdom. Figures such as **Bhishma**, **Vidura**, **Drona**, **Kripa**, **Karna** and **Shakuni** further influenced the political environment surrounding the royal family.

The Kuru family tree is therefore essential to understanding the committee's political dynamics. **Kinship, succession, loyalty and personal alliances are closely intertwined**, making the family structure more than a genealogical record—it forms the foundation upon which the larger struggle for political authority unfolds.

Major Kingdoms, Alliances & Political Landscape

The geopolitical map of ancient India (Bharatvarsha) during the Mahabharata era was defined by a complex web of clan loyalties, dynastic ties, strategic royal marriages, and competing regional hegemonies.

KURU COALITION (HASTINAPUR CORE)	PANDAVA ALLIANCE (INDRAPRASTHA AXIS)
- Hastinapur: Imperial power base & seat of ultimate authority. - Gandhara: strategic buffer; cavalry support (Shakuni). - Anga: Eastern stronghold granted to Karna by Duryodhana. - Trigarta, Sindhu, Kamboja, Bahlika: Key regional allies.	- Panchala: Primary military partner via Draupadi's alliance. - Dwaraka (Yadavas): Strategic support; Krishna's counsel. - Matsya: Crucial ally securing exile period shelter. - Magadha: Allied post-Jarasandha under King Sahadeva.

KEY REGIONAL KINGDOMS & STRATEGIC ROLES

Hastinapur: Major North Indian empire. Heavily fortified with vast treasury resources, but politically unstable due to succession ambiguity.

Indraprastha: Developed in Khandavaprastha by Pandavas; grew into an economic and architecture powerhouse rivaling Hastinapur prior to the dice game.

Panchala (King Drupada): Traditional rival of Hastinapur and Drona. The Pandava-Draupadi alliance secured Panchala's veteran forces.

Dwaraka (Yadava Confederation): Structurally neutral, but divided—Krishna aligned with Pandavas while his elite standing force (Narayani Sena) fought for Duryodhana.

Gandhara & Anga: Gandhara provided political strategy and cavalry; Anga secured eastern border dominance for Hastinapur.

DYNASTIC MARRIAGES AS GEOPOLITICAL TOOLS

Pandava-Panchala: Draupadi's polyandrous marriage unified Panchalan military clout with Pandava political legitimacy.

Arjuna-Subhadra: Tied the Pandavas directly to Krishna's immediate Vrishni clan.

Kuru-Gandhara & Kuru-Sindhu: Secured the vulnerable North-Western borders and trade corridors for Hastinapur.

Court Politics

THE SUCCESSION CRISIS

The Kuru conflict stems from fundamental contradictions in dynastic succession laws (Kula-dharma) and primogeniture customs:

- Dhritarashtra's Claim: Eldest son of Vichitravirya, but bypassed due to his congenital blindness. He harbored lifelong resentment over lost birthrights.
- Pandu's Claim: Crowned king due to physical fitness. His sudden retreat and death created a legal vacuum regarding regency versus permanent reign.
- Yudhishthira's Claim: Eldest prince of the next generation (Jyeshtha), born to the reigning King Pandu, widely accepted for his righteousness and administrative skills.
- Duryodhana's Claim: Contended that Dhritarashtra was the legitimate king all along, rendering Pandu's rule a temporary stewardship and making himself the true heir.

PALACE FACTIONS

- The War Faction (Duryodhana, Karna, Shakuni, Dushasana): Advocated absolute state power, aggressive expansion, and neutralizing Pandava claims entirely.
- The Elders / Institutionalists (Bhishma, Drona, Kripa): Bound by rigid oaths of fealty to the throne of Hastinapur rather than absolute ethics; paralyzed during constitutional crises.
- The Righteous Counsel (Vidura, Vikarna): Consistently advocated for rule of law, constitutional morality, and equitable division of territory.

Rajadharma and Moral Failure of the State Rajadharma dictates that a king's primary obligation is public welfare (Yogakshema) and neutral justice. Dhritarashtra's failure as a sovereign stemmed from his personal affection for his son (Putramoha) superseding his duties as monarch.

Sabha and Governance

The Kuru governance model relied on the Sabha (Royal Assembly), which functioned simultaneously as a supreme court, legislative body, and cabinet council.

The **Sabha** was an important institution within the political framework of the Mahabharata, functioning as a space for royal deliberation, diplomacy, counsel, administration and matters concerning the kingdom. The royal court of **Hastinapura** brought together the king, princes, elders, advisers and other influential figures, creating a political environment where authority and counsel operated alongside personal loyalties and competing interests.

Governance was closely associated with **Rajadharma**, under which the ruler was expected to protect the kingdom, uphold justice, maintain order and act in the interests of the realm. However, the Mahabharata also demonstrates how institutions of governance could fail when political interests, personal loyalties and authority overshadowed Dharma.

A prominent example is the **Dyuta Sabha—the Dice Game**, which represents a critical failure of the Kuru court. The assembly permitted a game of chance to determine matters involving **political authority, sovereignty and territorial possession**, despite the serious consequences involved. More significantly, when **Draupadi** was brought before the assembly and her dignity was threatened, the elders and members of the court failed to take decisive action. The episode exposes the consequences of institutional inaction when those entrusted with authority allow procedural arguments and competing interpretations of Dharma to prevail over immediate moral responsibility.

The Dice Game therefore demonstrates that the effectiveness of a political institution depends not merely upon its formal authority, but upon the willingness of those within it to exercise **judgement, accountability and responsibility**. For delegates, the Sabha provides an important framework for examining how governance can be strengthened or undermined by the individuals operating within it.

The Mahabharata consequently presents governance as a balance between **authority, counsel, Dharma and accountability**, where decisions made within the royal court can determine the political stability and future of the entire realm.

Military Organization

The Mahabharata outlines a rigorous hierarchical military structure based on standardized organizational metrics.

1 Akshauhini = 21,870 Chariots | 21,870 Elephants | 65,610 Cavalry | 109,350 Infantry Ratio Standard: 1 Chariot : 1 Elephant : 3 Cavalry : 5 Foot Soldiers

Ratio Standard: 1 Chariot : 1 Elephant : 3 Cavalry : 5 Foot Soldiers

Total Force Strength: Kaurava Army = 11 Akshauhinis (~2.4 Million) | Pandava Army = 7 Akshauhinis (~1.5 Million)

WARRIOR CLASSIFICATIONS

- Rath: Standard commander skilled in archery and tactics, capable of engaging 1,000 soldiers.
- Atirath: Advanced strategist capable of fighting 10,000 combatants simultaneously (e.g., Kritavarma).
- Maharath: Elite general commanding supreme weaponry and celestial armaments (Astras), equal to 60,000 warriors (e.g., Bhishma, Drona, Karna, Arjuna, Abhimanyu).

TACTICAL FORMATIONS (VYUHAS)

- Chakravyuha: Defensive multi-tiered rotating wheel designed to trap invading forces. Used on Day 13.
- Krauncha Vyuha: Offensive bird-shaped array designed to penetrate deep center lines.
- Padma Vyuha: Concentric lotus formation used for absolute protection of high commanders.

Vyūha - Battle Formation



1. Chakra Vyūha (चक्रव्यूह) — Circular, multi-layered formation designed to surround and isolate the opponent; famously associated with Abhimanyu on the 13th day.



2. Padma Vyūha (पद्मव्यूह) — Lotus-shaped formation with successive layers of troops, providing both protection and strategic depth.



3. Garuda Vyūha (गरुडव्यूह) — Eagle-shaped formation with distinct head, wings and body, allowing forces to concentrate and strike strategically.

4. Krauncha Vyūha (क्रौंचव्यूह) — Crane-shaped formation with a pointed centre, useful for concentrating force and breaking enemy lines.

5. Makara Vyūha (मकरव्यूह) — Crocodile-shaped formation designed to create a strong and organized battlefield deployment.

6. Kurma Vyūha (कूर्मव्यूह) — Tortoise-shaped defensive formation, emphasizing protection of the centre and resilience against attacks.

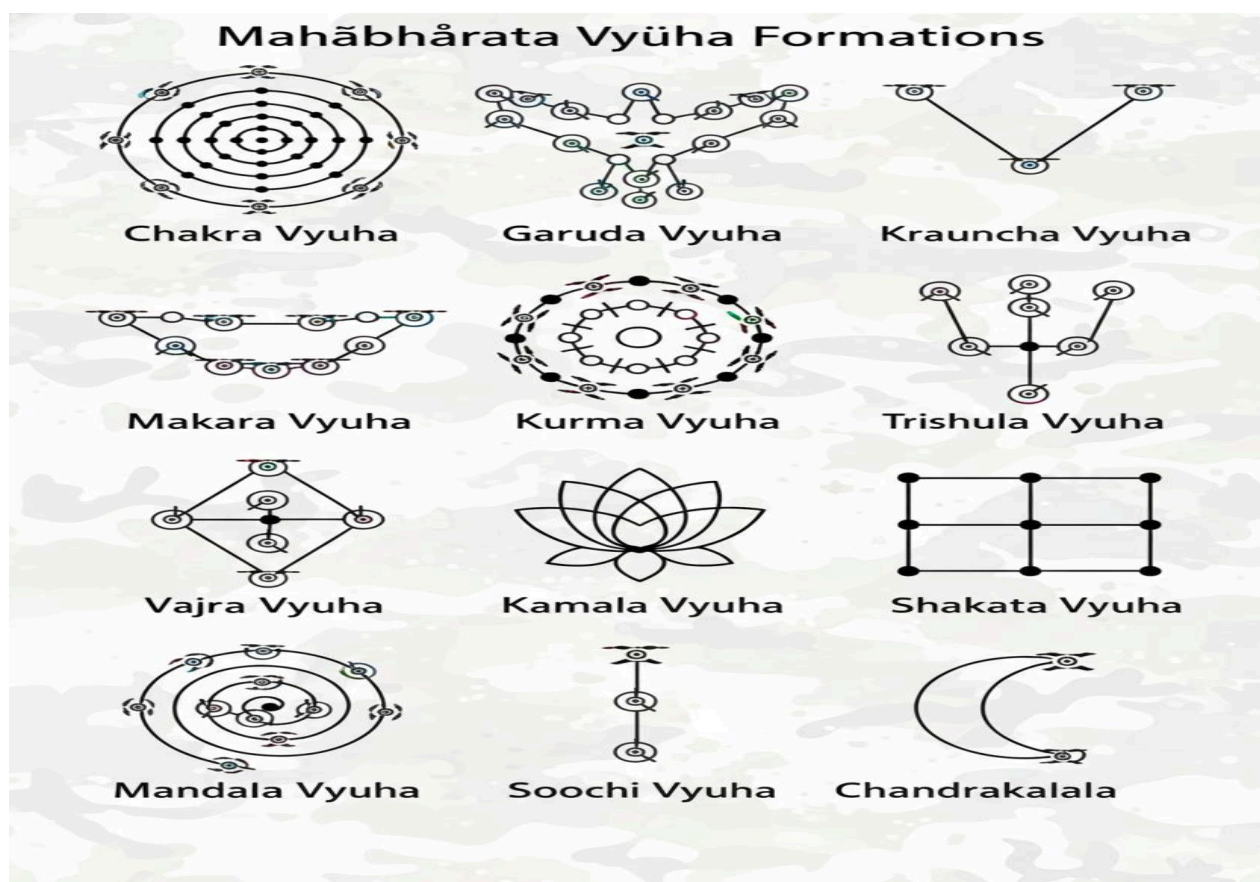
- 7. Mandala Vyūha (मंडलव्यूह)** — Circular formation enabling troops to operate and respond from multiple directions.
- 8. Vajra Vyūha (वज्रव्यूह)** — Thunderbolt-shaped formation designed around a powerful, concentrated striking force.
- 9. Shakata Vyūha (शकटव्यूह)** — Cart-shaped formation, creating a structured arrangement capable of protecting important divisions.
- 10. Suchimukha Vyūha (सूचिमुखव्यूह)** — Needle-shaped formation with a narrow, pointed front intended for penetrating enemy lines.
- 11. Ardha-Chandra Vyūha (अर्धचंद्रव्यूह)** — Crescent-shaped formation with curved wings, allowing forces to surround or envelop opposing troops.
- 12. Sringataka Vyūha (शृंगटकव्यूह)** — Horn-shaped formation with projecting ends, designed to exert pressure from multiple points.
- 13. Oormi Vyūha (ऊर्मिव्यूह)** — Wave-shaped formation representing a flexible and flowing movement of troops across the battlefield.
- 14. Sarvatobhadra Vyūha (सर्वतोभद्रव्यूह)** — An all-sided defensive formation designed to remain protected and combat-ready from every direction.
- 15. Sarvatomukha Vyūha (सर्वतोमुखीव्यूह)** — Formation in which troops face multiple directions, reducing vulnerability to attacks from the rear or flanks.
- 16. Syena Vyūha (श्येनव्यूह)** — Hawk/falcon-shaped formation, using a concentrated central force with extended wings for strategic attack.
- 17. Trishula Vyūha (त्रिशूलव्यूह)** — Trident-shaped formation with three projecting sections, enabling attacks or pressure along multiple fronts.
- 18. Asura Vyūha (असुरव्यूह)** — A formation named after the Asuras; its exact battlefield geometry is less clearly described in surviving accounts.
- 19. Deva Vyūha (देवव्यूह)** — A formation named after the Devas, representing an organized and strategically arranged battle array.
- 20. Garbha Vyūha (गर्भव्यूह)** — An inward, layered formation symbolizing an enclosed centre protected by successive ranks.
- 21. Mala Vyūha (मालाव्यूह)** — Garland-shaped arrangement in which different divisions are linked into a continuous strategic formation.
- 22. Sarpa Vyūha (सर्पव्यूह)** — Serpent-shaped, winding formation allowing troops to move in a flexible and deceptive pattern.
- 23. Surya Vyūha (सूर्यव्यूह)** — Sun-shaped formation with forces organized around a central point and extending outward.

24. Mahisha Vyūha (महिषव्यूह) — Buffalo-shaped formation, representing a broad and forceful deployment of troops.

25. Nakshatra-Mandala Vyūha (नक्षत्रमंडलव्यूह) — Constellation-like circular formation using a distributed arrangement of forces across the battlefield.

26. Chakra-Shakata Vyūha (चक्र-शकटव्यूह) — A combined wheel-and-cart formation, creating a complex arrangement of defensive and offensive divisions.

27. Khadga-Sarpa Vyūha (खड्ग-सर्पव्यूह) — Sword-and-serpent formation combining a sharp striking element with a flexible, winding deployment.



NOTE: Description and classifications of Vyūhas vary across textual traditions and later interpretations. The formations listed below are presented as traditional descriptions rather than a single standardized military manual.

Shastra and Astra

- **Brahmastra** — ब्रह्मास्त्र — Weapon of Brahma
- **Brahmashira Astra** — ब्रह्मशिरास्त्र — Supreme Brahma weapon
- **Pashupatastra** — पाशुपतास्त्र — Weapon of Shiva
- **Narayanastra** — नारायणास्त्र — Weapon of Narayana
- **Vaishnavastra** — वैष्णवास्त्र — Weapon of Vishnu
- **Brahmanda Astra** — ब्रह्माण्डास्त्र — Cosmic weapon
- **Agneyastra** — आग्नेयास्त्र — Fire weapon
- **Varunastra** — वरुणास्त्र — Water weapon
- **Vayavyastra** — वायव्यास्त्र — Wind weapon
- **Indrastra / Aindrastra** — इन्द्रास्त्र / ऐन्द्रास्त्र — Weapon of Indra
- **Vajrastra** — वज्रास्त्र — Thunderbolt weapon
- **Nagastra** — नागास्त्र — Serpent weapon
- **Nagapasha** — नागपाश — Serpent noose
- **Garudastra** — गरुडास्त्र — Weapon of Garuda
- **Agni Astra** — अग्न्यास्त्र — Fire-based divine weapon
- **Suryastra** — सूर्यास्त्र — Weapon associated with Surya
- **Somastra** — सोमास्त्र — Weapon associated with Soma
- **Kuber Astra** — कुबेरास्त्र — Weapon of Kubera
- **Kaumara Astra** — कौमारास्त्र — Weapon associated with Kartikeya
- **Bhaumastra** — भौमास्त्र — Weapon associated with Bhumi
- **Tvasht Astra** — त्वाष्ट्रास्त्र — Weapon of Tvashta
- **Mohanāstra** — मोहनास्त्र — Weapon causing bewilderment
- **Prasvāpanāstra** — प्रस्वापनास्त्र — Sleep-inducing weapon
- **Sammohanāstra** — सम्मोहनास्त्र — Weapon causing mass bewilderment
- **Varshanastra** — वर्षणास्त्र — Rain-producing weapon
- **Shoshanastra** — शोषणास्त्र — Drying/withering weapon
- **Parjanyastra** — पर्जन्यास्त्र — Storm/rain weapon
- **Brahmadanda** — ब्रह्मदण्ड — Divine Brahma's staff
- **Bhargavastra** — भार्गवास्त्र — Weapon associated with Bhargava/Parashurama

Kurukshetra war- Timeline and key Battles

The Kurukshetra War is traditionally described in the *Mahabharata* as an **18-day conflict between the Pandavas and Kauravas**, preceded by years of political rivalry, failed diplomacy, succession disputes and competing claims to legitimate rule. The war is therefore not merely a military confrontation but the culmination of a prolonged struggle over **authority, succession, alliances and Rajadharma**.

Before the War

Lakshagrah - An attempt to kill the Pandavas by trapping them in a palace constructed at Varnavata using highly combustible materials.

Dice Game & Exile — Yudhishtira loses the kingdom in the dice game and the Pandavas undergo **13 years of exile**, including one year in concealment.

Return & Claim to the Kingdom — After completing the exile, the Pandavas seek the restoration of their rights. Negotiations fail to produce a settlement.

Krishna's Peace Mission — Krishna travels to Hastinapura as an emissary and seeks a peaceful settlement. The negotiations fail, and preparations for war begin.

Alliance Formation — Both sides gather kings, commanders and military forces. Krishna offers his army to one side and himself, without weapons, to the other. The Pandavas choose Krishna, while the Kauravas receive the Narayani army.

Key Strategic Turning Points

1. Fall of Bhishma — Removes the Kauravas' most experienced commander.

2. Abhimanyu's Death — Intensifies the conflict and triggers Arjuna's vow against Jayadratha.

3. Death of Jayadratha — Demonstrates the importance of time-bound objectives and battlefield formations.

4. Fall of Drona — Marks a major shift in Kaurava command and raises questions about truth, deception and warfare.

5. Death of Karna — Removes Duryodhana's principal remaining champion.

6. Defeat of Duryodhana — Effectively ends organised Kaurava resistance.

Committee Relevance: The war demonstrates how **diplomacy, succession disputes, alliance-building, intelligence, strategic formations and competing interpretations of duty** can transform a political dispute into a full-scale conflict.

18 Day War:

Day Major Development

1– 10 Bhishma as Commander: Bhishma leads the Kaurava army. The Pandavas struggle against his battlefield prowess.

Day 10 Fall of Bhishma: Shikhandi is placed before Arjuna, allowing Arjuna to strike Bhishma. Bhishma falls and remains on a bed of arrows.

11–15 Drona as Commander: Dronacharya assumes command. The Kauravas attempt increasingly complex strategies to break the Pandava forces.

Day 13 Abhimanyu & Chakravyuha: Abhimanyu enters the Chakravyuha. Unable to receive support after the formation closes, he is killed.

Day 14 Vow of Arjuna: Arjuna seeks to defeat Jayadratha before sunset because of his role in preventing the Pandavas from reaching Abhimanyu. Jayadratha is killed.

Day 15 Fall of Drona: Drona lays down his arms after hearing that Ashwatthama is dead; the statement refers to an elephant named Ashwatthama. Drona is subsequently killed.

16–17 Karna as Commander: Karna assumes command of the Kaurava forces. His confrontation with Arjuna becomes one of the central battles of the war.

Day 17 Death of Karna: During his duel with Arjuna, Karna's chariot becomes immobilised. Arjuna kills Karna following Krishna's intervention and guidance.

- Day 18** **Shalya as Commander:** Shalya leads the remaining Kaurava forces. Yudhishtira kills Shalya. The Kaurava army is effectively destroyed.
- End of Day 18** **Duryodhana's Final Duel:** Duryodhana fights Bhima with maces. Bhima strikes Duryodhana on the thigh and defeats him.
- After the war** **Night Attack:** Ashwatthama, Kripa and Kritavarma attack the sleeping Pandava camp. The surviving warriors of the Pandava side suffer heavy losses.

Key Words & Sanskrit Glossary

1. **Dharma** — Righteous duty and ethical conduct.
2. **Rajadharma** — Duties and responsibilities of a ruler.
3. **Artha** — Material prosperity, wealth and political interests.
4. **Niti** — Principles of governance and statecraft.
5. **Rajya** — Kingdom or realm.
6. **Sabha** — Royal/political assembly.
7. **Mantri** — Minister or royal advisor.
8. **Doot** — Diplomatic envoy or messenger.
9. **Sandhi** — Treaty or peaceful agreement.
10. **Vigraha** — Conflict or hostility between states.
11. **Guptachar** — Spy or intelligence operative.
12. **Sama** — Persuasion or conciliation.
13. **Dana** — Offering or concession to secure cooperation.
14. **Bheda** — Creating divisions among opponents.
15. **Danda** — Coercive authority or punishment.
16. **Vyuha** — Strategic military formation.
17. **Chakravyuha** — A complex circular/spiral battle formation.
18. **Astra** — Divine or supernatural weapon.
19. **Shastra** — Conventional physical weapon.
20. **Senapati** — Commander-in-chief of an army
21. **Akshauhini** — A traditional large military unit described in the *Mahabharata*, consisting of a prescribed proportion of chariots, elephants, cavalry and infantry.
22. **Dharma-Yuddha** — Warfare conducted according to prescribed principles or rules of righteous combat
23. **Kurukshetra** — The battlefield where the great war of the *Mahabharata* is traditionally said to have occurred.

24. **Kshatriya Dharma** — Duties and expected conduct traditionally associated with the warrior and ruling class.

Dharma, warfare and ethics

DHARMA-YUDDHA (RULES OF JUST WAR)

Prior to combat, both belligerents ratified standard Geneva-style conventions of warfare:

- Combat Hours: Engagements occur strictly between sunrise and sunset.
- Parity Rule: Direct combat only between equal force classes (chariot vs. chariot, foot soldier vs. foot soldier).
- Protection of Non-Combatants: Charioteers, armor-bearers, surrendering troops, and retreating soldiers were strictly immune from targeting.

ETHICAL EROSION DURING KURUKSHETRA (KUTA-YUDDHA)

As casualties escalated, strategic survival replaced codified rules, degrading the conflict into asymmetric warfare:

- Killing of Abhimanyu (Day 13): Multiple Maharathis encircled and executed an unarmored, dismounted youth.
- Fall of Bhishma (Day 10): Arjuna placed Shikhandi in front of his chariot, knowing Bhishma's personal vow forbade fighting Shikhandi.
- Fall of Drona (Day 15): Misleading statement regarding the death of "Ashwatthama" (the elephant) used to break Drona's resolve.
- Fall of Karna (Day 17): Arjuna struck Karna while he was dismounted and attempting to free his mired chariot wheel.
- Night Massacre (Post-War): Ashwatthama's nocturnal raid on the sleeping Pandava camp, violating all norms of night combat immunity.

QARs — Questions a Resolution Must Answer

1. How should legitimate succession to the throne be determined when multiple claimants have competing rights?
2. What mechanisms can prevent disputes over succession and territory from escalating into armed conflict?
3. What responsibilities should a ruler uphold when personal interests, family loyalties and Rajadharma conflict?
4. How can the Sabha and royal advisors ensure that major decisions are not driven by court intrigue, favouritism or manipulation?
5. What diplomatic mechanisms should be used to resolve disputes between kingdoms before war becomes inevitable?
6. What role should envoys, neutral kingdoms and respected statesmen play in mediating political conflicts?
7. How should espionage and intelligence networks be regulated while protecting the kingdom's security?
8. What limits should govern the use of strategic deception and unconventional tactics during warfare?
9. How can alliances and military mobilisation be managed without creating an irreversible path towards war?
10. What political and institutional safeguards should be established after a conflict to prevent future succession disputes from resulting in another civil war?

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